FOOD FOR AWAKENING

A Meditation Study Guide on Appropriate Attention

1. Understanding Attention (*Manasikāra*)

In contemporary spiritual circles, mindfulness is frequently equated with a state of "bare attention"—a purely receptive, non-reactive, and non-judging awareness. However, the Buddha's teachings in the Pāli Canon reveal a radically different perspective: **attention never occurs in a bare, pure, or unconditioned form**. It is always colored by views, perceptions, and intentions. In the chain of dependent co-arising, attention (*manasikāra*) arises under the category of "name" (*nāma*) and is deeply conditioned by ignorance (*avijjā*), fabrication (*sankhāra*), and sensory consciousness (*vinnāna*).

If we assume that our attention is already unconditioned, we mistake a highly conditioned mental state for Awakening itself. To dismantle suffering, we must recognize that attention is conditioned and consciously train it to become **appropriate attention** (*yoniso manasikāra*)—framing our experiences systematically in terms of the Four Noble Truths.

> **THE CORE INGREDIENTS OF MEDITATION PRACTICE**
> • **Mindfulness (*Sati*):** Not a passive state of receptivity, but a faculty of active memory. It is the ability to call to mind—and keep in mind—skillful instructions, intentions, and frames of reference (such as the breath) over time.
> • **Alertness (*Sampajañña*):** Being actively aware of what you are doing in the present moment as you are doing it, tracking both bodily and mental actions.
> • **Ardency (*Ātappa*):** The persistent, willful effort to act skillfully, develop wholesome qualities, and abandon unskillful ones (Right Effort).
> • **Appropriate Attention (*Yoniso Manasikāra*):** The practice of framing experience in terms of the Four Noble Truths, asking questions that target the end of stress rather than abstract self-identity.

2. The Metaphor of Feeding

The fundamental insight of the Buddha's Awakening was **conditionality**: that experiences arise in dependence on specific causes. In teaching young novices, the Buddha famously illustrated this with a basic truth: *"All beings subsist on food."* If suffering is a conditioned phenomenon, it can be brought to an end by starving it of its conditions. Appropriate attention acts as the gatekeeper of this process—strategically starving unskillful habits (the hindrances) while actively feeding the factors of Awakening.

3. Starving the Five Hindrances (*Nīvarana*)

The *Āhāra Sutta* (The Food Discourse, SN 46.51) explains that the five mental hindrances are active blockages to concentration and wisdom. They do not arise randomly; they are fed by inappropriate attention to specific themes. By deliberately shifting both the **focus** and the **quality** of our attention, we cut off their food supply and starve them out of the mind.

Mental Hindrance	Fed By (Inappropriate Attention)	Starved By (Appropriate Attention)
Sensual Desire *Kāmacchanda*	Focusing inappropriately on the **theme of beauty** (*subha-nimitta*); dwelling on the attractive aspects of sensory objects and infatuations.	Directing attention to the **theme of unattractiveness** (*asubha-nimitta*); analyzing the physical reality of the body and the transience of sensuality.
Ill Will *Byāpāda*	Focusing inappropriately on the **theme of irritation** (*patigha-nimitta*); obsessing over annoying features, offenses, or grievances.	Cultivating the **sublime attitudes** (*brahmavihāras*): goodwill (*mettā*), compassion (*karunā*), empathetic joy (*muditā*), and equanimity (*upekkhā*).
Sloth and Torpor *Thīna-middha*	Paying attention to feelings of **boredom, laziness, drowsiness, and sluggishness**; yielding to mental fog or physical heaviness.	Focusing on **present potentials for energy, effort, and persistence** (*viriya*); stirring up active interest and bodily alertness.
Restlessness and Anxiety *Uddhacca-kukkucca*	Focusing inappropriately on the **lack of stillness** in the mind; obsessing over regrets, future worries, or chaotic thoughts.	Directing attention to **any present mental stillness**; finding and encouraging small, quiet pockets of calm within the breath.
Uncertainty *Vicikicchā*	Focusing on **abstract, conjectural, or speculative topics** that cannot be resolved through immediate experience (e.g., "Who am I? Do I exist?").	Paying attention to **skillful and unskillful qualities** currently present in the mind; analyzing what leads to harm and what leads to peace.

To apply these starvation protocols in daily meditation, you must treat your attention as a dynamic tool. For example, if anger arises, do not bottle it up or vent it. Use appropriate attention to change how you breathe (dissolving physical discomfort) and then look for the good points of the person who irritated you. Shifting the focus of attention to their good points is not sentimentality; it is a vital strategy to protect your own mind from the toxic karma of ill will.

4. Feeding the Seven Factors for Awakening (*Bojjhanga*)

While hindrances must be starved, the Seven Factors for Awakening—**mindfulness, analysis of qualities, persistence, rapture, serenity, concentration, and equanimity**—must be fed. Unlike the hindrances, which are starved by changing the *object* of attention, the Awakening factors are fed primarily by changing the **quality** of your attention.

The *Āhāra Sutta* notes that each factor has a potential "basis" in experience. Appropriate attention to that basis stimulates and develops the corresponding factor. Crucially, the basis for the second factor—**analysis of mental qualities** (*dhamma-vicaya-sambojjhanga*)—is the presence of skillful and unskillful qualities in the mind. Paying appropriate attention to these qualities not only develops discernment but also starves the hindrance of uncertainty. This analytical quality of mind acts as the active, investigative engine of the entire path.

5. Deconstructing Self-Identity: The Aggregates

One of the most powerful applications of appropriate attention is the active deconstruction of self-identity. We habitually glue our experiences together to form a solid sense of "me" or "mine." According to the *Khemaka Sutta* and SN 22.122, a meditator must train themselves to apply appropriate attention to the five clinging-aggregates: physical form, feelings, perceptions, fabrications, and consciousness.

Rather than viewing these aggregates as a permanent home, appropriate attention systematically frames them through eleven deconstructive perceptions. By labeling every sensory and mental event under these categories, the mind ceases to locate its identity within the changing currents of conditioned experience. This systematic dismantling starves the underlying craving that drives becoming, paving the way for release.

> **THE ELEVEN DECONSTRUCTIVE PERCEPTIONS (SN 22.122)**
> To cut through the illusion of selfhood, a meditator must use appropriate attention to label and view each of the five clinging-aggregates (form, feeling, perception, fabrications, consciousness) as:
> 1. **Inconstant (*Anicca*)** — Ever-changing and unreliable.
> 2. **Stressful (*Dukkha*)** — Inherently incapable of satisfying the heart.
> 3. **A Disease** — An unnatural, unstable affliction.
> 4. **A Cancer** — An invasive, uncontrollable growth of suffering.
> 5. **An Arrow** — A source of constant, piercing irritation.
> 6. **Painful** — Marked by distress and discomfort.
> 7. **An Affliction** — A burden that weighs heavily on the mind.
> 8. **Alien** — Foreign, belonging to nature rather than "me."
> 9. **A Dissolution** — Crumbling apart moment-by-moment.
> 10. **An Emptiness** — Devoid of lasting, core substance.
> 11. **Not-Self (*Anatta*)** — Not under your absolute, permanent control.

6. The Threshold of Release: Non-Fashioning (*Atammayatā*)

As appropriate attention and concentration mature, the mind learns to let go of gross fabrications and settle into highly refined states of equanimity. However, even the highest levels of concentration are willed, fabricated, and warded by intention. The ultimate breakthrough occurs when the mind moves from equanimity to **non-fashioning** (*atammayatā*, literally "not-made-of-that-ness"). This is the stage where the mind adds absolutely nothing to sensory data.

In the famous *Bāhiya Sutta* (Ud 1:10), the Buddha delivers a swift, deconstructive instruction to the highly motivated wanderer Bāhiya: *"In reference to the seen, there will be only the seen. In reference to the heard, only the heard..."*

This instruction is not a description of a passive, bare awareness. It is a highly active, willed training. It requires robust mindfulness to remember the intention to block passion, aversion, and delusion from landing on sensory contact. As SN 35.95 states, when forms and feelings are met with firm mindfulness and dispassion, they immediately fall away without amassing stress. By actively holding the intention outlined in MN 106—*"It should not be, it should not occur to me; it will not be, it will not occur to me. What is, what has come to be, that I abandon"*—the mind starves the nucleus around which self-identity is constructed.

When passion has no place to land, there is no "here," no "there," and no "between the two." At this precise threshold of non-fashioning, the final willed intention to undercut passion is dropped. With no further fabrication occurring, the mind breaks through the conditioned sphere entirely, realizing the **unconditioned Deathless—Nibbāna**.

> **PRACTICE SUMMARY: THINK LIKE A MASTER COOK**
> The Buddha compared the practice of meditation to the skills of a palace cook. You cannot improve the taste of a soup simply by dumping more and more pepper (representing mindfulness) into it. If the soup is out of balance, you must inspect your spice rack and add onion, garlic, or oregano as needed.
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> Similarly, if your mind is flustered and irritated, you must add gentleness and contentment. If your mind is lazy or drowsy, you must rev up your sense of urgency by contemplating death or examining unwholesome states. Learn to label your mental qualities clearly so that you know which "spice" to apply in the laboratory of the breath. Use appropriate attention to bring the mind to balance, and eventually, to the peace of the Unfabricated.